

middle register able to conjure touching lyricism.” She and Rossini were married in 1822. This portrait of her, aged about 50, is by Johann Baptist Reiter.

With its famous overture (used as the theme tune for the television series *The Lone Ranger*) and its monumental scale (it lasts over four hours), *William Tell* was a landmark in the development of grand opera. It boasted magnificent sets, huge choruses, graceful ballets, and some of Rossini’s most stirring melodies. Opening in 1829, the piece was enthusiastically received and also frequently revived, clocking up some 500 performances in the course of the composer’s lifetime.

*William Tell* was also Rossini’s swan song. Although aged just 37, he never wrote another opera in the remaining 39 years of his life. The reasons for his retirement are unclear: he suffered from various ailments, so health may have been a cause; or he may have sensed that his style was going out of fashion. In any event, Rossini spent his final years composing some religious music—including the ironically titled *Petite Messe solennelle* (1863), which was neither “little” nor “solemn”—indulging his love of good food, and enjoying the well-earned celebrity that his music had brought him.